

1785. James Hutton presents his theory that Earth is much older than was previously believed, and that Earth’s crust is continuously changing.

1809. Jean-Baptiste Lamarck publishes Philosophie Zoologique, where he argues that animals acquire characteristics as a consequence of use or non-use of different body parts, triggering mutations over generations.

1813. In his Essay on the Theory of the Earth, Georges Cuvier suggests that fossils are the remains of extinct creatures wiped out by periodic “catastrophic” events.

1823. Amateur fossil hunter Mary Anning uncovers the first intact plesiosaurus skeleton.